PART I · PITCH · TIPS

When a note reads wrong

Most wrong notes come from a handful of slips. Name the slip first, then fix only that note: playing the whole line again rarely finds it.

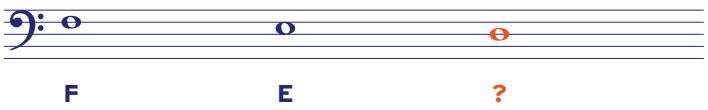
TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
The left hand reads like the right	**the clef**: bass lines are G B D F A, not E G B D F	p. 26
You land an octave too high or too low	**the Cs**: find Middle C first, then walk out to Bass C or Treble C	p. 22
Notes above or below the staff slow you down	**the ledger lines**: step on from the nearest staff line	p. 26
A sharp or flat vanishes, or stays too long	**the bar line**: a sign lasts only to the end of its bar	p. 36
You play the black key on the wrong side	**the direction**: sharp goes right, flat goes left	p. 35
Two notes sound too close or too far apart	**the interval**: count the notes, then the keys between	p. 41

EXAMPLE

Spot the slip



Sam played B. Wrong!

1. **Check the clef first:** this is the bass clef, not the treble.
2. **Start from the clef note:** the dots hug line 4, F.
3. **Step down** to the red note on line 3: F, E …

The note is **D**. Sam read the bass staff with treble names (treble line 3 is B): the most common slip of all.

HOW TO

Three checks before you read a new line

1. **The clefs:** which staff is treble, which is bass?
2. **The clef notes:** find treble G, bass F and Middle C, and read the other notes from them.
3. **The signs:** mark each sharp, flat or natural, and see where its bar ends.

THINK OF IT Like reading a map: find the big landmarks first, then the streets around them. A note far from every clef note is the one most often misread.